UNIT 5

Gender and Culture

film • media • advertisement • literature • gender issues • language • relationships

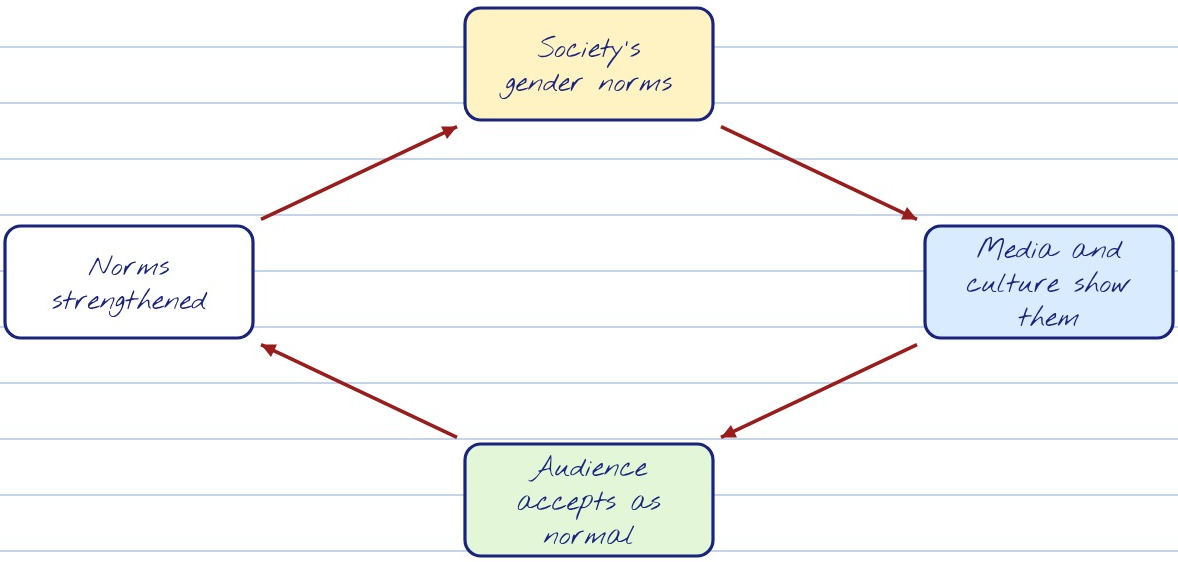
1. Gender and Culture: Introduction

Culture = shared values, beliefs, customs, art, language and media of a society. Culture **shapes** our ideas of "masculine" and "feminine", and in turn media and art **reflect and reinforce** those ideas.

Q1. How are gender and culture related?

Ans. Culture decides what is "proper" for men and women; popular culture (films, TV, ads, books, songs, social media) repeats these ideas daily until they look natural.

- Culture can **reproduce** stereotypes (obedient heroine, aggressive hero).
- It can also **challenge** them through feminist films, women writers, campaigns.



Key idea

- Media is a mirror (reflects society) and a hammer (shapes society). Learn to read it critically = **media literacy**.

2. Gender and Film

Q2. How are women and men represented in films?

Ans. Mainstream cinema often shows women as objects of desire, sacrificing mothers, ideal wives or vamps, and men as strong heroes, saviours and rescuers.

- **Women** : decorative roles, item songs, passive romantic interest, victim to be rescued, "good vs bad woman" binary.
- **Men** : hyper-masculine action heroes, violent, stalking shown as romance ("no means yes").

- **Behind camera** : very few women directors, writers, cinematographers - **male gaze** (Laura Mulvey, 1975).
- **Positive change** : women-centred films, strong female leads, parallel and regional cinema (e.g., Mother India, Arth, Mirch Masala, Queen, Thappad, Kahaani, Dangal, Chak De India), trans and queer stories now appearing.

Traditional portrayal	Progressive portrayal
Woman = bride, mother, sacrifice	Woman = individual with goals
Hero rescues heroine	Women rescue themselves, partners support
Stalking, harassment = "romance"	Consent and respect = love
Item song, body display	Dignity, varied body types and ages
Male lead drives plot	Women-led narratives

Bechdel Test (Alison Bechdel, 1985)

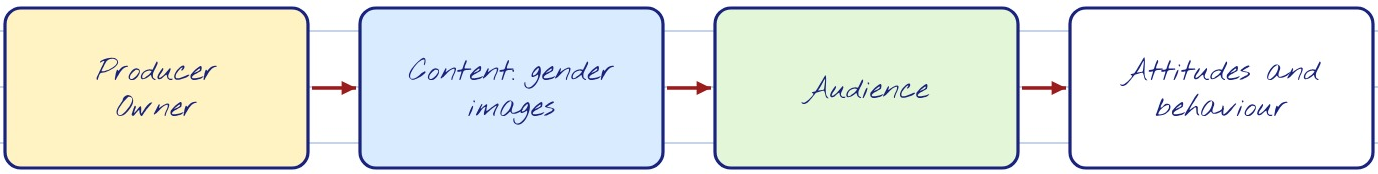
- Does a film (1) have at least two named women, (2) who talk to each other, (3) about something other than a man?
- Many popular films fail; the test is a simple check of women's presence in stories.

3. Gender and Electronic Media

Q3. Discuss the role of electronic media (TV, radio, internet, social media) in shaping gender.

Ans. Electronic media reaches millions daily and strongly influences attitudes of children and adults.

- **Television serials** : women as scheming, weepy or self-sacrificing; family and marriage-centred stories.
- **News** : fewer women experts and anchors in serious news; crimes reported in sensational or victim-blaming style.
- **Reality shows and music videos** : objectification and stereotypes.
- **Internet and social media** : empowering (voice, campaigns like #MeToo, #HeForShe, #BringBackOurGirls) but also **trolling, cyber-stalking, morphing, body shaming.**
- **Gaming and OTT** : male-dominated worlds; improving with diverse characters.



Positive uses

- Awareness campaigns, helplines, women's radio (community radio), online education and e-commerce for women entrepreneurs.
- Safe-use skills : privacy settings, reporting, cyber-law (IT Act 2000 s. 66E, 67; cybercrime portal 1930).

4. Gender and Advertisement

Q4. How do advertisements portray gender? Discuss the issues.

Ans. Advertising sells products by selling images - and often sells gender stereotypes too.

- **Women** : housewives promoting cleaning, kitchen and food products; "perfect" fair, slim body for beauty products; used as sex objects to sell cars, perfumes, tyres.
- **Men** : strong, tough, earning, rarely seen doing housework or care.
- **Children** : pink for girls (dolls), blue for boys (cars).
- **Issues** : objectification, body image problems, colour bias (fairness creams), unrealistic beauty, reinforcing unequal division of labour.

Product type	Typical gender image
Detergent, kitchen, food	Woman as cook-cleaner
Cars, bikes, finance	Man as driver-earner
Beauty and fairness creams	Woman must please by looks
Toys	Girls = dolls, boys = machines
Deodorants, razors	Male power, female attraction

Q5. What laws and codes control indecent or sexist advertising?

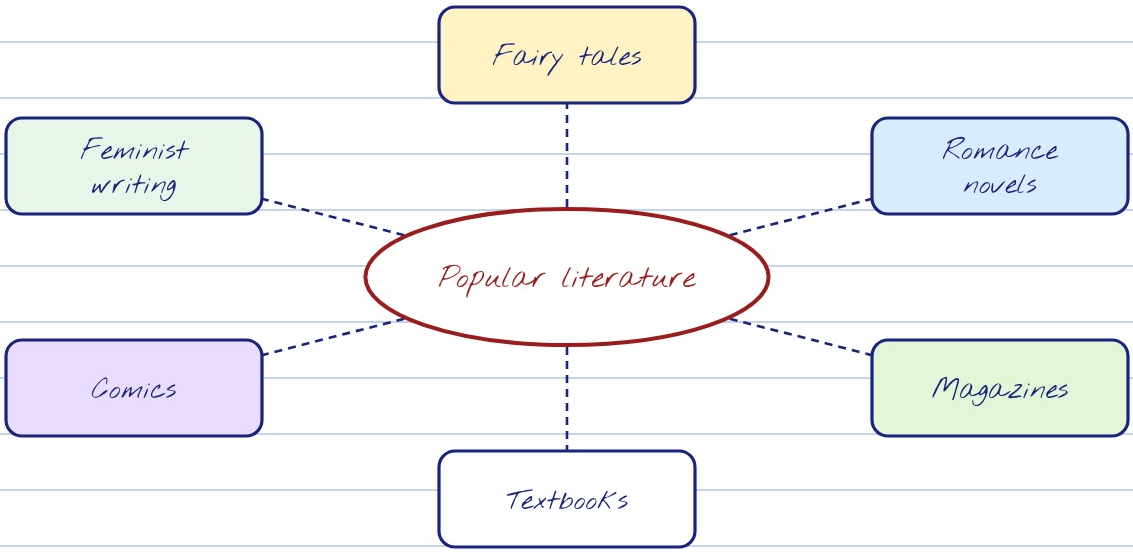
- **Indecent Representation of Women (Prohibition) Act, 1986** : bans indecent depiction in ads, publications, films.
- **ASCI Code** (Advertising Standards Council of India) : ads must not be demeaning to women.
- Cable TV Rules, CBFC certification, Press Council guidelines, IT Rules for online content.
- Good practice examples : campaigns breaking stereotypes (men sharing housework, diverse body types, "#ShareTheLoad").

5. Gender and Popular Literature

Q6. How is gender shown in popular literature (novels, magazines, comics, folktales)?

Ans. Popular books, romance novels, magazines and children's stories often keep old gender patterns - but women writers and feminist authors challenge them.

- **Folk and fairy tales** : passive princess waiting for rescue, evil stepmother and witch, hero is brave and saves.
- **Magazines** : women's magazines focus on beauty, cooking, relationships, men's on sports, cars, business.
- **Romance and thriller novels** : ideal of dominant male and submissive female, violence glamourised.
- **Textbooks** : men in professions, women at home, improved by gender audits.
- **Counter-narratives** : Ismat Chughtai, Mahasweta Devi, Kamala Das, Amrita Pritam, Arundhati Roy, Taslima Nasrin, Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni, Dalit and queer writing.



Read with a gender lens

- Who is the hero and who tells the story? Who speaks and who is silent?
- Are women shown as individuals or only in relation to men?
- Which values (power, honour, obedience) are praised?

6. Women in Sports, Music and Social Media

Q7. How are gender norms seen in sports, music and social media?

- **Sports** : women athletes get less coverage, pay and prize money, "girls can't play" myths, success of **P.V. Sindhu, Mary Kom, Mirabai Chanu, Saina Nehwal, Indian women's cricket team** challenges them.
- **Music and songs** : lyrics objectify women or glorify stalking, some songs promote respect and equality.

- **Social media** : beauty filters, body shaming, trolling of women who speak out, also platforms for solidarity.
- **Religion and tradition** : rituals that exclude menstruating women or restrict who may perform rites - debates on equal access (Sabarimala, Haji Ali cases).



Media literacy : 5 questions to ask

- 1. Who made this and why? 2. Who is shown, who is missing? 3. How are women and men portrayed?
- 4. What values are being sold? 5. How could it be shown fairly?

Q8. Case study - analyse an advertisement

- A soap advert shows only the mother cooking and washing while father reads the newspaper.
- Stereotype : housework = women's work. Effect : children learn unequal roles.
- Better version : both parents share chores, child of any gender helps.

7. Gender Development Issues

Q9. List major gender development issues in India.

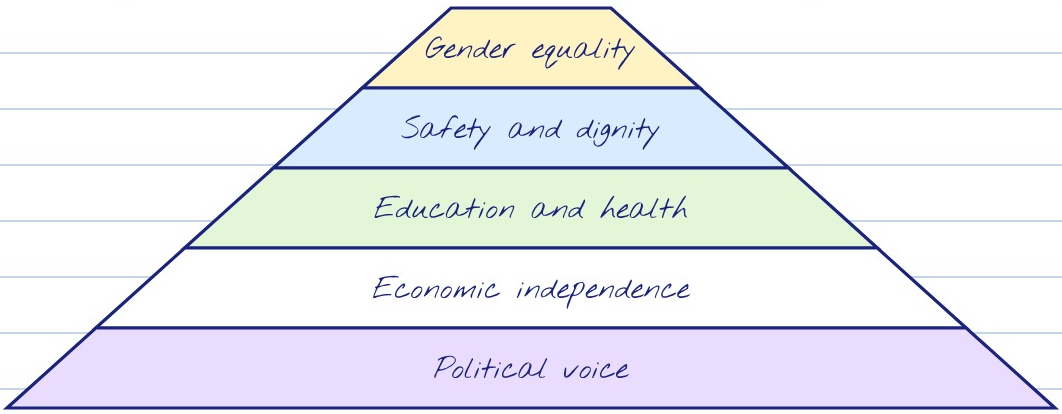
- **Education** : female literacy lags, girls' drop-out after puberty, safety and distance issues.
- **Health** : maternal mortality, anaemia, malnutrition, unsafe abortion, mental health ignored.
- **Work and income** : low female workforce participation, wage gap, unpaid care, no asset ownership.
- **Political** : low women's representation (Women's Reservation Act 2023 aims one-third).
- **Safety** : violence, trafficking, child marriage, harassment.
- **Digital divide** : fewer women own and use phones and internet.

Programme	Aim
Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (2015)	Girl child survival and education
Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana	Savings for girl child
Mahila Shakti Kendra, SHGs (NRLM)	Skills, credit, empowerment
Ujjwala Yojana	Clean cooking fuel for women
Poshan Abhiyaan	Nutrition of mothers and children
Women's Reservation Act 2023	One-third seats in legislatures

8. Gender Issues (Current Concerns)

Q10. Mention some contemporary gender issues.

- Violence and safety; unequal pay; glass ceiling; sexual harassment at work.
- Son preference and declining sex ratio; child marriage; dowry.
- Rights of **transgender and queer persons** : stigma, jobs, health.
- Women's reproductive rights and health; access to menstrual hygiene.
- Online abuse, cyber-stalking; portrayal in media; mental health of men and boys.
- Intersection of **gender with caste, class, religion, disability**.



9. Gender-Sensitive Language

Language both reflects and creates our attitudes. Words like "mankind" and "chairman" treat men as the default, proverbs and abuses often insult women.

Q11. What is gender-sensitive language? Give examples.

Ans. Language that treats all genders equally, avoids stereotypes and includes everyone.

Gender-biased	Gender-sensitive
Mankind	Humankind, people
Chairman	Chairperson, chair
Policeman, fireman	Police officer, firefighter
Businessman	Businessperson
Manpower	Workforce, staff
Housewife	Homemaker
Girl (for adult woman)	Woman
Lady doctor, male nurse	Doctor, nurse
He or his (for all)	They, he or she, the person

- Avoid sexist jokes, abuse based on women's bodies, and "boys will be boys".
- Use **neutral titles** (Ms.), pronouns people prefer, and inclusive terms for transgender persons.
- Use equal visuals and examples in classrooms, forms and documents.

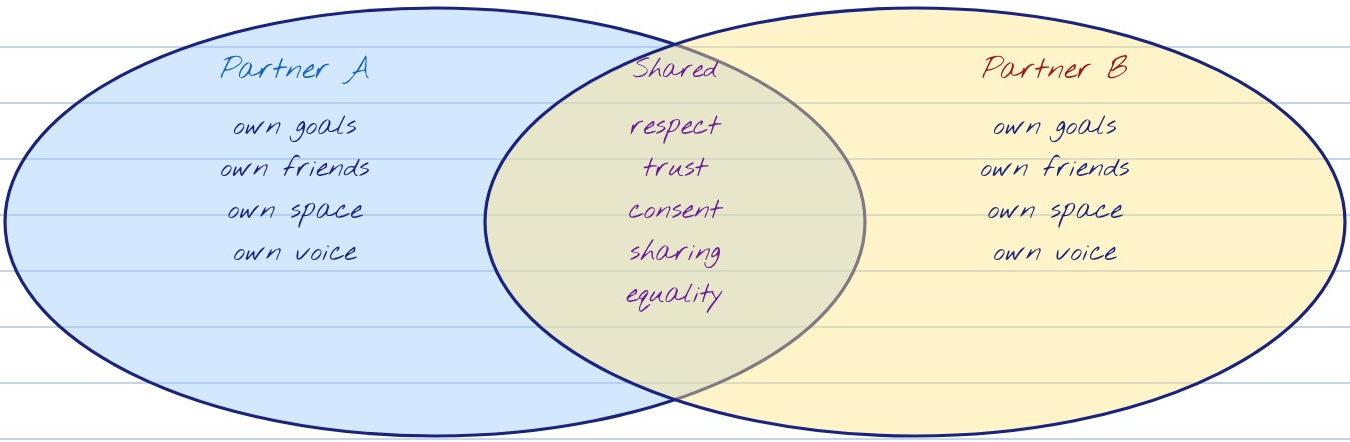
Change the words -> change the thought -> change the practice.

10. Just Relationships

Q12. What are "just relationships"? What are their key features?

Ans. Relationships based on equality, respect, consent, trust and shared responsibility - in family, friendship, love, work and society - free from domination and violence.

- **Mutual respect** and dignity; no superiority by gender, caste, class.
- **Consent** : "yes" is freely given; no pressure, no coercion; the right to say NO.
- **Equal decision making**; open communication and listening.
- **Shared responsibilities** : housework, parenting, money.
- **Non-violence** and accountability; space for individual growth and friendships.
- Support during conflict through dialogue, counselling, not control.



Signs of a healthy vs unhealthy relationship

- Healthy : trust, honesty, freedom, safety, equal say, kindness in disagreement.
- Unhealthy : jealousy, control of phone and clothes, threats, put-downs, isolation, violence - seek help early.

11. Objective and Long Questions

Q13. Quick recall

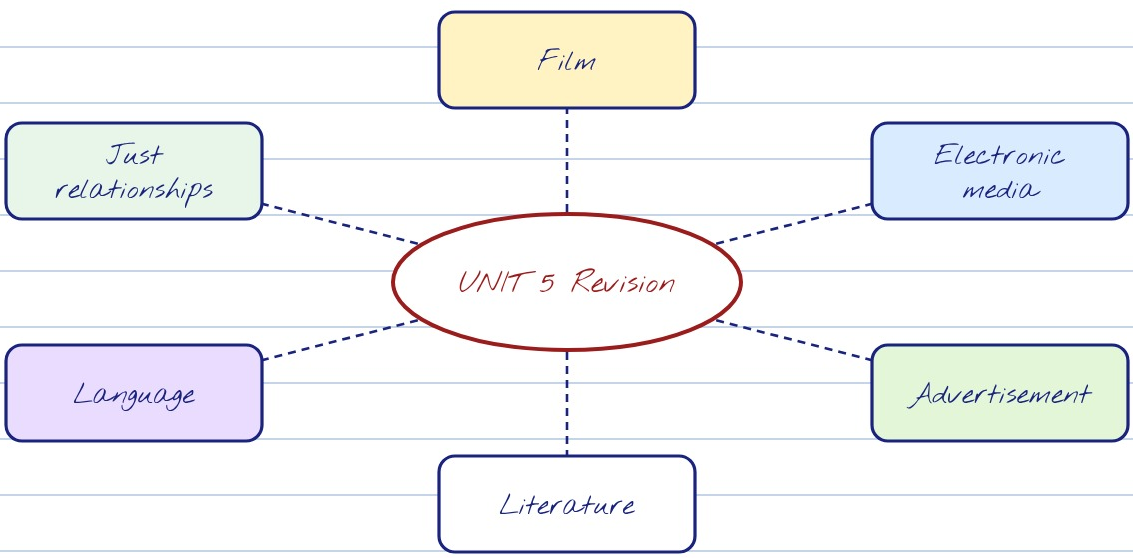
- 1. "Male gaze" - **Laura Mulvey**. 2. Bechdel test checks **women's presence in films**.
- 3. Indecent Representation of Women Act - **1986**. 4. Chairman -> **chairperson**.
- 5. Equal respect, consent and sharing = **just relationship**. 6. Community radio is a **positive** use of media.

Q14. Long answers

- 1. Portrayal of gender in film and electronic media. (Sec. 2, 3)
- 2. Gender and advertisement: stereotypes, laws and remedies. (Sec. 4)
- 3. Gender in popular literature, role of women writers. (Sec. 5)
- 4. Gender development issues and gender issues today. (Sec. 7, 8)
- 5. Gender-sensitive language and just relationships. (Sec. 9, 10)

Equal words, equal images, equal relationships = an equal world.

12. Two-Mark Questions and Quick Revision



Q15. Two-mark questions

- 1. **Male gaze** : looking at women through a heterosexual male viewpoint, as objects of pleasure.
- 2. **Objectification** : treating a person as a thing, valued only for looks.
- 3. **Stereotype in media** : repeated simplistic image such as the "ideal housewife".

> 4. **Media literacy** : ability to read and question media messages.
> 5. **Gender-sensitive language** : words that treat all genders equally and inclusively.
> 6. **Consent** : free, informed, reversible agreement without pressure.
> 7. **Bechdel test** : two named women talk to each other about something besides a man.
> 8. **ASCI** : self-regulatory body checking misleading or offensive advertisements.

Medium	Typical gender issue	Positive change
Film	Male gaze, item songs	Women-led stories
TV and OTT	Weepy, scheming women	Diverse characters
Advertisement	Housewife and sex object	Shared roles, real bodies
Social media	Trolling, body shaming	#MeToo, awareness